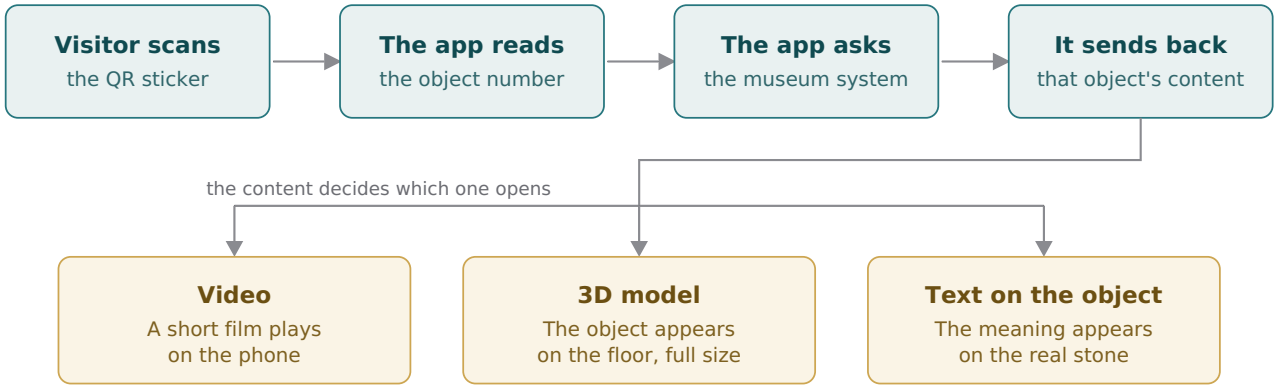
How the Smart Museum Guide works

Colombo National Museum · Mobile Visitor Guide

26 October 2026

Part 1 — How a visitor uses the app

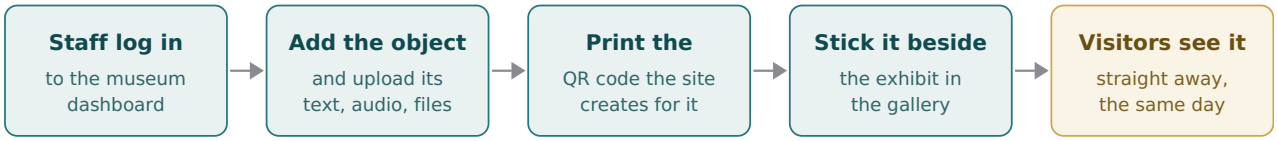
The visitor does one thing: scan the code. The app works out the rest.



In every case, the explanation is spoken in English, Sinhala or Tamil

Part 2 — How museum staff add a new object

Staff do this themselves, through a simple website. No developer is involved.



No new version of the app is needed. The museum can add objects at any time.

What version 1 costs

Version 1 is built and tested using free services. The development fee is the only cost.

Item	Cost
Development of version 1 — four weeks of work	LKR 50,000 – 60,000
Database and file storage, while building and testing	No charge
Staff dashboard hosting	No charge
Total for version 1	**LKR 50,000 – 60,000**

Costs that begin when the app is published

These start only when the museum decides to release the app to the public. They are paid by the museum directly to Google, Apple and the hosting service, and are separate from the development fee.

Item	Cost	How often
Google Play account, to publish on Android	~LKR 8,400	Once only
Apple Developer Program, to publish on iPhone	~LKR 33,000	Every year
Database and storage, once real visitors begin using it	~LKR 100,000	Every year
Museum's own web address (optional)	~LKR 4,000	Every year

The Apple fee must be renewed every year. If it lapses, Apple removes the app from the App Store until it is paid again. The Android fee is paid once and never again.

Planned for a later stage

A fourth experience, for carved panels. The visitor points the phone at the carving and small labels appear on the different figures. As the narration explains each part, that label lights up in turn.

This is more complex than the three above and is not part of the first version. It can be added later without changing anything the museum already has.